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DPON-152-E
June 2019

Dealing With Difficult Characters: Improving Work Relationships Through Empathy

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Introduction

If you have ever worked in an organization, undertaken an MBA or simply come from a large family, you will have undoubtedly come across a difficult character. Indeed, "no matter how clever, charming or pleasant, most people have some unfortunate aspect to their personality."[1]

For many, understanding why it is harder to build a working relationship with such characters proves rather difficult. Fortunately, there has been a significant amount of research on what has been termed "dark side traits" of personality.[2] Dark side traits (henceforth called "dark traits") are aspects of personality that, if not kept in check, can manifest in behaviors that might be, to a larger or smaller degree, related to symptoms of personality disorders.[3] These traits can cause the person—and, of equal importance, those around him or her—significant problems, especially in a work context. Take, for example, the long-suffering employee whose boss regularly steals the credit for his or her work in a display of the bold (or narcissistic) dark trait, or the manager who is unable to delegate due to his or her excessive perfectionism and micromanages his or her subordinates, demonstrating obsessive-compulsive tendencies.

Examples of these traits are rife in the workplace. Literature on toxic workers, rudeness and incivility at work is abundant.[4] Hogan estimates that most people display at least three dark side

[1] Rob Kaiser, "Dealing with the Dark Side," *Talent Quarterly*, Issue no.8 (2016).

[2] Robert Hogan, and Joyce Hogan, "Assessing Leadership: A View from the Dark Side," *International Journal of Selection and Assessment* 9(1–2) (2001): 40–51.

[3] See IESE Technical Note by Alberto Ribera, Florencia Sortheix and Sofia Arvanitou, "Personality Traits and Personality Disorders," DPON-63-E, 2007.

[4] See, for instance: Christine Porath, and Amir Erez, "Does rudeness really matter? The effects of rudeness on task performance and helpfulness," *Academy of Management Journal* 50(5) (2007): 1181–1197.

This technical note was prepared by Jolyon Sayer, MBA 2018, Professor Alberto Ribera and Nia Plamenova, research assistant. June 2019.

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Last edited: 6/19/19

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traits and about 40% of people have one or two that put them at risk of derailing their career.[5] As one would expect with such a commonplace issue, the topic of dealing with dark traits has also been well covered in academic research and management literature. However, the focus to date has been on how to manage one's own dark traits.

This note aims to offer some orientations to help when working with difficult people: bosses, peers and subordinates, or customers, clients, etc. It might help you to spot other people's dark traits, enable you to understand how people you find bothersome, stressful—perhaps even toxic—are feeling, understand the temperament structure behind a difficult character and provide advice on how to deal with a difficult personality.

Firstly, it is not necessary to view another person's dark traits as wholly negative. Indeed, the trait may well be the reason behind their success to date; for example, the methodical, perfectionist (perhaps a bit obsessive) subordinate who earns a promotion to manager off the back of their consistent diligence. One can view dark traits as strengths that are overused when under pressure, and hence, turn into weaknesses. However, the debilitating effect of a dark trait will eventually derail a career if left unchecked.[6]

People with difficult characters can be remarkable and achieve incredible things. Think of some of the business titans of the last 50 years, and you will likely suspect many of possessing dark traits. Indeed, Steve Jobs had a reputation for being overbearing, temperamental and insensitive, yet is hailed as one of the great visionaries of his era.

Many of the great characters in literature are extremely difficult people. Consider Sherlock Holmes, who demonstrates quite a few dark traits and is a timelessly captivating character as a result. Holmes is, in fact, a good example of the power of dark traits and how to deal with them. Holmes was reliant on his sidekick, Dr. Watson, to curb the more extreme areas of his personality and remain a force for good. On a less extreme level, this paper aims to help others adopt the Watson role when necessary. It helps the user to spot and value the strengths linked to dark traits and provides practical advice on how to deal with sufferers.

Finally, a couple of caveats: it is important to note that an indispensable requisite for a difficult character to change is for the individual to take responsibility for his or her own life. The desire to change is the key to affecting change. Unfortunately, many people either lack the self-awareness or the persistence to make the sustained effort that is required: "most people don't really want to change; they want to *have* changed."[7]

Furthermore, this note should not be viewed as a foolproof guide to spotting dark traits and especially not personality disorders. It takes years of training to master such skills.

How to Spot a Dark Side Trait

The best way to spot difficult characters (and, consequently, their dark traits) within organizations and particular individuals is to seek feedback from subordinates.[8] People are on

[5] Tomas Chamorro-Premuzic, "Could your Personality Derail your Career?" *Harvard Business Review*, September (2017): pp. 1-5

[6] Jason Pierce, and Herman Aguinis, "The too-much-of-a-good-thing effect in management," *Journal of Management* 39*(2)* (2013):313–338.

[7] Tomas Chamorro-Premuzic, "Could your Personality Derail your Career?" *Harvard Business Review*, 2017.

[8] Frank Shipper, and Clark Wilson, "The Impact of Managerial Behaviors on Group Performance, Stress and Commitment," in *Impact of Leadership*, eds.

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their best behavior in front of bosses and important customers, while they tend to display some of the dark traits when they are more relaxed. The true measure of someone's character comes when a person is less constrained by social etiquette or lacks the incentive to behave well.

Personality tests provide another key tool for identifying dark traits. Personality tests will show up what personality disorder a person is most at risk from. As discussed in the introduction, the dark traits are linked to symptoms of personality disorders, although someone exhibiting dark traits does not necessarily have a disorder.

Table 1 shows the temperament combinations (based on Cloninger's Temperament Character Inventory [TCI-R])[9] that are linked to each personality disorder. "All categories of personality disorder are distinguished by low TCI self-directedness,"[10] regardless of the disorder. Low self-directedness is manifested through an inability to accept responsibility for one's actions, a tendency to blame others for poor decisions and a lack of self-confidence combined with an unrealistic choice of goals.[11] Furthermore, most individuals with personality disorders "are low in cooperativeness, which is defined by poor interpersonal functioning and is described as being intolerant, narcissistic, hostile or disagreeable, revengeful and opportunistic."[12]

Kenneth Clark, and David Campbell (Greensboro, N.C.: Center for Creative Leadership, 1992), 119–129.

[9] For a complete explanation of the TCI-R model and psychometric personality assessment, see IESE Technical note DPON-62-E: Alberto Ribera, SofiaArvanitouand Florencia Sortheix,"The Bio-Psycho-Social-Model of Personality," 2008.

[10] C. Robert Cloninger,"A Practical Way to Diagnosis Personality Disorder: a Proposal," *Journal of Personality Disorders*. Volume 14, Issue nº 2 (2000): pp. 99-108.

[11] Tannis Laidlaw, Prabudha Dwivedi, Akira Naito, and John Gruzelier, "Low self-directedness (TCI), mood, schizotypy and hypnotic susceptibility," *Personality and Individual Differences*, 39(2) (2005): 469–480.

[12] Ibid.

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Table 1
Temperament Combinations Linked to Personality Disorders

Temperament	Novelty Seeking	Harm Avoidance	Reward Dependence	Characteristics	Risk Disorder (TRAIT)
Adventurous	High	Low	Low	Risk-prone, courageous and results-driven, versatile, ambitious, capable in confronting difficulties and opposition	Anti-social (Mischievous)
Passionate	High	Low	High	Trusting, affectionate, versatile, makes a good first impression, attention-seeking and perhaps manipulative	Histrionic/ Narcissistic (Colorful/Bold)
Sensitive	High	High	High	Open, friendly, makes a good first impression, attention-seeking, poor at accepting feedback and criticism, and easily upset	Narcissistic/ Histrionic (Bold/Colorful)
Variable	High	High	Low	Unpredictable, frequent mood swings. May evolve to an explosive temperament that is characterized as easily upset (frustrated or distressed)	Borderline (Excitable)
Methodical	Low	High	Low	Loyal, modest, perfectionist, rigid, high-strung, private and distrusting	Obsessive-Compulsive (Diligent)
Independent	Low	Low	Low	Composed (rarely frustrated or distressed), private, imaginative and cold	Schizoid/ Schizotypal (Detached/ Imaginative)
Reliable	Low	Low	High	Composed (rarely frustrated or distressed), careful, scrupulous, candid, trusting, traditional	Dependent (Dutiful)
Cautious	Low	High	High	Slow-tempered, perfectionist, careful, deferential, suspicious and perhaps revengeful	Paranoid/ Avoidant (Argumentative/Leisurely)
Flexible	Average	Average	Average	Balanced, reliable and adaptable to new situations; they are rarely frustrated or distressed	

Recent research has emphasized the need for disorders and related dark traits to be viewed in clusters. The point of creating such clusters is not to pigeonhole people, but rather to demonstrate tendencies and to understand better the commonalities between some of the 10 types of personality disorders. In fact, the latest edition of the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* (DSM-5)[13], published by the American Psychiatric Association in 2013, refers to three categories or clusters: the odd/eccentric (cluster A); the dramatic/emotional (cluster B); and the anxious/fearful (cluster C).

[13] American Psychiatric Association. Diagnostic and statistical manual of mental disorders (DSM-5®). American Psychiatric Pub, (2013).

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Similarly, Hogan and Kaiser have identified three clusters that dark traits fall into: seduction, intimidation and ingratiation. For the purposes of this paper, we will focus on dark traits, outlined in Table 2,[14] where we have outlined how the traits are classified in each cluster, as well as their clinical version, observable traits, upside and downside.

Table 2
Dark Trait Clusters

Dark Side Trait	Clinical Version	Observable Traits	Upside	Downside
Cluster 1: Seductive Traits				
Bold	Narcissistic	Has strong opinions, competitive, confident and assertive, self-promoting	Assertive, driven	Arrogant, poor at receiving feedback
Colorful	Histrionic	Attracts attention, wants to be noticed, life of the party, easily bored, does several things at once	Charming, entertaining, expressive	Socially obtuse
Mischievous	Anti-social/Psychopathic	Spontaneous, smooth-talking, bends the rules, doesn't follow through on promises	Risk-tolerant, charmingly persuasive	Impulsive, manipulative
Imaginative	Schizotypal	Eccentric, unusual appearance, unconventional	Creative, visionary	Wacky, little application
Cluster 2: Ingratiating Traits				
Diligent	Obsessive-Compulsive	Good with details, organized, sets very high standards, resistant to change	Hardworking, high standards, attention to detail	Perfectionist, micromanaging
Dutiful	Dependent	Supportive, forgiving and tolerant, prefers working with others, needs others' support	Loyal, hardworking	Submissive, avoids confrontation
Cluster 3: Distancing Traits				
Excitable	Borderline		Passionate, enthusiastic	Volatile, prone to outbursts
Skeptical	Paranoid	Analytical, shrewd, enjoys debating, oversensitive, overly critical, self-centered	Politically astute, hard to fool	Mistrustful, quarrelsome
Cautious	Avoidant	Unassertive, change resistant, slow at making decisions	Careful, precise	Indecisive, risk-averse
Reserved	Schizoid	Reserved, formal, withdrawn, aloof and cold, thick-skinned	Stoic, calm under pressure	Uncommunicative, insensitive
Leisurely	Avoidant	Very confident, easygoing, procrastinates	Relaxed, easygoing	Passive-aggressive

[14] Based (with some modifications) on Rob Kaiser, "Dealing with the Dark Side," *Talent Quarterly*, Issue 8, pp. 37-42.

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For the sake of practicality, in this note we look at specific dark traits, as we are interested in patterns of behavior. However, please bear in mind that considering traits in isolation can lead to warped conclusions and misunderstandings.

Map of the Most Common Dark Traits

The following section is designed to help you to both spot dark side characteristics and to give you a window into how such characters view the world, which, in turn, should improve your empathy toward them.[15]

Bold (Narcissistic)

What you may observe:

- Strong opinions, expectation of special consideration, self-promotion, direct and assertive, intensely competitive and prone to taking advantage of others.
- At their best, bold people are "energetic, charismatic, leader-like and willing to take the initiative to get projects moving."
- At their worst, they are "arrogant, overbearing, demanding, self-deceived and pompous."

What they're thinking:

- Bold people expect to be liked, admired, attended to, praised and indulged. They expect to succeed at everything they undertake. When such needs and expectations are frustrated, they can lose their temper.
- They often test the limits of what is permissible, because they are so confident of success: narcissists "see things that never were and ask: Why not?"[16]
- They see themselves as crucial to a team's success and will therefore take more credit than is warranted or fair and refuse to acknowledge failure, errors or mistakes.

Colorful (Histrionic)

What you may observe:

- Crave recognition, attract attention, entertaining, easily bored, do several things at once, good public speakers.
- At their best "they are bright, entertaining, fun, flirtatious and the life of the party."
- At their worst "they don't listen, they don't plan, they self-nominate and self-promote and they ignore negative feedback."

[15] Adapted from: Robert Hogan, and Joyce Hogan, "Assessing Leadership: A View from the Dark Side," *International Journal of Selection and Assessment,* 9 (1–2) (2001): 40–51.

[16] Michael Maccoby, "Narcissistic Leaders: the Incredible Pros, the Inevitable Cons," *Harvard Business Review*, 82 (1) (2004): pp.92-101.

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What they're thinking:

- Colorful people have incredible stage presence and lack self-consciousness. As a result, "they perform extremely well in interviews, in assessment centers and other public settings."
- These people "deal with stress and heavy workloads by becoming very busy; they enjoy high pressure and high drama situations because they can be the star."
- "They confuse activity with productivity and evaluate themselves in terms of how many meetings they attend rather than how much they actually get done."

Mischievous (Anti-Social)

What you may observe:

- Spontaneous, charming and fun-loving smooth-talkers. Do not follow through on promises, bend the rules, enjoy being in the fast lane, have no regrets, want quick results.
- At their best, they are "charming, fun, engaging, courageous and somewhat seductive."
- At their worst, they are "impulsive, reckless, remorseless and exploitative. They also have problems with honesty, are quite manipulative and can talk their way out of any problem."

What they're thinking:

- Mischievous people "expect that others will like them and find them charming; consequently, they expect to be able to extract favors, promises, money and other resources from other people with relative ease."
- "They see others as utilities to be exploited and therefore have problems maintaining commitments and are unconcerned about violating expectations."
- These people "handle stress and heavy workloads with great aplomb. They are easily bored, and find stress, danger and risk invigorating." However, they "adapt poorly to the requirements of structured bureaucracies."

Imaginative (Schizotypal)

What you may observe:

- Unusual appearance, creative, generate unusual ideas, eccentric, get distracted.
- At their best, imaginative people are: "bright, insightful, imaginative, playful and innovative."
- At their worst, they can be "self-absorbed, insensitive to others and indifferent to the social and political consequences of their single-minded focus on their own agendas."

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What they're thinking:

- Imaginative people are "constantly alert to new ways of seeing, thinking and expressing themselves and they enjoy the reactions they are able to elicit in other people with their unusual forms of self-expression."

Diligent (Obsessive-Compulsive)

What you may observe:

- Perfectionists, good with details, organized, disciplined and thorough, plan every detail, set very high standards, overly conscientious, resistant to change, precise and accurate.
- At their best they are good organizational citizens who can be relied upon to maintain standards, do their work competently and professionally, and treat people with respect.
- At their worst they can be "fussy, nit-picking micromanagers who deprive their subordinates of any choice or control over their work." The micromanagement alienates their staff. They also have problems with vision and the big picture.

What they're thinking:

- Diligent characters are "concerned with doing a good job, being good citizens and pleasing authority. They are hard-working, careful, planful, meticulous and have high standards of performance for themselves and other people. They live by these rules, they expect others to do so too and they become irritable when others don't follow their rules."
- These people also cause a lot of stress for themselves; their obsessive concern for quality and high performance makes it difficult for them to delegate. It also makes it difficult for them to prioritize their tasks: if something is worth doing, it's worth doing well.

Dutiful (Dependent)

What you may observe:

- Soothing and comforting, supportive and helpful, warm and congenial, need others' support, forgiving and tolerant, defer to others' opinions, prefer working with others rather than alone, loyal followers, self-sacrificing.
- At their best these people are "polite, conforming and eager to please . . . they rarely make enemies."
- At their worst "they have problems making decisions, taking initiative or taking stands."

What they're thinking:

- Dutiful characters are "deeply concerned with being accepted and with getting along [with people] especially authority figures."
- "They are alert for signs of disapproval and for opportunities to ingratiate themselves, to be of service, to demonstrate their loyalty to the organization."

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Excitable (Borderline)

What you may observe:

- Often frustrated with others, impatient and irritable, moody and negative, hard to please, self-defeating, overreact, volatile and unpredictable, quick to anger.
- At their best, excitable people have huge capacity for empathy; their view of life as unfair allows them to feel others' pain. They also tend to be enthusiastic about, and to work very hard on, new projects."
- At their worst they can require a lot of hand-holding and constant reassurance. They can also hold grudges based on perceived injustices.

What they're thinking:

- Excitable people expect to be disappointed in relationships; they anticipate being rejected, ignored, criticized or treated unfairly and are therefore on guard for signs that others have or will treat them badly. They find signs of mistreatment everywhere, even when others can't see it.
- When they think they have been mistreated, they can erupt in emotional displays that may involve yelling, throwing things and slamming doors.

Argumentative/Skeptical (Paranoid)

What you may observe:

- Skeptical people tend to be analytical and shrewd but also oversensitive, easily offended and argumentative.
- At their best they are "very insightful about organizational politics and the motives of their counter-players and they can be the source of good intelligence regarding the agendas of others and the meaning of events." On account of their unwavering belief in how the world works, "they can be visionary and charismatic, and people may be drawn to them."
- At their worst they handle stress poorly, "going into their bunkers, withdrawing into their ideology and then attacking that which is threatening them." Over time, they "tend to accumulate enemies."

What they're thinking:

- Skeptics expect to be wronged, betrayed or cheated. They are "keenly alert for signs of mistreatment and when they think it has happened, they retaliate severely." Warning signs include "accusations or litigation."
- "They inevitably find 'signs of betrayal' even though others might not see them."

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Cautious (Avoidant)

What you may observe:

- Cautious people are uneasy with strangers, easily embarrassed, cautious and worried.
- At their best they can be: "prudent, careful and meticulous about evaluating risk; they will rarely make rash or ill-advised moves, and they provide sound, prudential advice about intended future courses of action."
- At their worst they can "avoid innovation, resist change, stall and drag their feet, even when it's apparent that something needs to be done." Under stress and heavy workloads "they begin to adhere religiously to established procedures and will rely on the tried and true rather than on any new technology or other procedures." They are unpopular managers "because they are so cautious, indecisive and controlling."

What they're thinking:

- Cautious people "fear being criticized, shamed, blamed or somehow disgraced." They are constantly on guard against the possibilities of making errors or mistakes" and will therefore struggle to take the initiative or responsibility.

Detached (Schizoid)

What you may observe:

- Detached personalities appear reserved and formal. They are often detached, cold and aloof, although their comfort in their own company often leads to a thick skin and independent and tough characters.
- At their best they are very tough in the face of adversity, taking criticism and opprobrium on the chin where others would tremble. This allows them to cope well under pressure.
- At their worst "they ignore others' needs, moods or feelings and can be rude, tactless, insensitive and gauche."

What they're thinking:

- Detached characters prefer to work alone and are more interested in data than in people.
- This can cause them to seem "self-absorbed, self-focused, indifferent to the feelings or opinions of others." They are "introverted, misanthropic, imperceptive and lacking social insight."

Leisurely (Avoidant)

What you may observe:

- Leisurely characters tend to procrastinate, claim to feel overburdened, hurried and pressured. They will criticize authority and come across as bold and very confident.

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- At their best they often have good social skills and can appear unnaturally confident and assured in their own abilities.
- At their worst, especially when pressed for additional output, they get angry and slow down even more. They tend to feel mistreated, unappreciated and put upon.

What they're thinking:

- Leisurely people "march to the sound of their own drum, they are confident about their skills and abilities, cynical about the talents and intentions of others—especially superiors—and insist on working at their own pace."
- They believe that others have received unfair advantages and use it to justify not playing by the rules.

How to Deal with Dark Side Traits

General Advice

Regardless of the dark trait exhibited, it is crucial that you do not take the actions of the difficult character personally. By trying to understand their behavior (using the previous section as a guide) you will recognize that their actions are not a personal attack.

Generally, dark side features come out when people "are not careful about managing their impressions—when they are stressed, tired, hungry, inebriated or just don't care."[17] This leads to the obvious conclusion that the best way of dealing with people with difficult characters is to keep them fresh, well-fed, sober and motivated. However, this is not always possible at the sharp end of business. What's more, the people most exposed to long hours and intense pressure are likely to be the leaders in an organization, and therefore in a position to cause a company the most damage.

Furthermore, bear in mind that when you observe some of the characteristics outlined in the previous section, it does not mean that the subject of your observations is suffering a personality disorder. It is most likely that they are at risk of a dark trait due to vulnerabilities in their temperament structure and occasionally suffer weak moments when their habits of character fail them (perhaps because of intense pressure, fatigue, sleep deprivation,[18] etc.).

How to Deal With a Difficult Character Over Whom You Have Little Influence

The most difficult position to find yourself in regarding dark traits is to have a boss who exhibits them. You are not in a position to call them out on it (in the hope that generating self-awareness is the first step to management of a disorder) nor can you insist on behavior adjustments. As Kaiser puts it: "an employee has three choices: suffer, quit or adapt[19]."

[17] Rob Kaiser, "Dealing with the Dark Side," *Talent Quarterly*.

[18] MIcheal Christian, and Aleksander Ellis, "Examining the effects of sleep deprivation on workplace deviance: A self-regulatory perspective," *Academy of Management Journal* 54(5) (2011): 913–934.

[19] Rob Kaiser, "Dealing with the Dark Side", *Talent Quarterly*.

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In addition, the average boss or employee is not a trained psychiatrist. The goal should not be to reconstruct personalities but to help your colleagues control their disturbing side in critical situations by adapting your own behavior.

Below are some simple techniques you can use to improve your relationship with a difficult character:[20]

Bold (Narcissistic)

- Keep them flattered by praising success, and never create a sense of betrayal (be sure feedback isn't too threatening).
- When you disagree, be sure to make it clear how an alternative solution will benefit them (and be open to them later taking credit for it).
- Such a character needs support with the nitty-gritty details of bringing plans to fruition. If you can fill this void, it will improve your relationship.

Colorful (Histrionic)

- Ensure they have consistent support and validation, regardless of their mood.
- Do not take abrupt mood-swings personally.
- Supplement their lack of attention to detail with extra organizational focus, translating their flashes of genius into workable opportunities.
- Avoid oversharing personal information that might be used against you in the workplace
- Try not to be responsive to their emotional experiences.

Mischievous (Anti-Social)

Unfortunately, this is perhaps one trait that may force you to quit. However, should you choose to adapt, bear the following in mind:

- Do not expect gratitude or loyalty and be prepared for uncertainty.
- Be mindful of their propensity to bend the rules to achieve personal gain and ensure the company is not at risk as a result.
- Make very specific and small requests about what you need (support, resources, feedback, etc.) to carry out your work.
- When it is necessary to address a sensitive issue, make sure the timing is right and the person is in relatively good spirits.
- Anticipate reactions and prepare for multiple scenarios.
- Set clear boundaries and maintain them to protect yourself, as people with mischievous tendencies tend to aim their dark behaviors at those who seem more easily manipulated.

[20] Adapted from: Laurence Millar, "From Difficult to Disturbed: Understanding and Managing Dysfunctional Employees",New York: AMACOM , American Management Association, (2008).

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Imaginative (Schizotypal)

- Ask clarifying questions when they share ideas or give you tasks, to avoid any problems in the application.
- Inform them frequently about your objectives, tasks and progress to counteract their distracted nature.
- Do not criticize unrealistic ideas directly but try to outline in a very clear way some practical aspects of their implementation to enable them to understand the extent to which their idea is feasible.

Diligent (Obsessive-Compulsive)

- Be prepared to work hard and know that you will be rewarded for your dedication.
- Attempt to get a clear picture of their expectations at every stage of the project.
- Do not be afraid to ask for directions, far better to require additional support than to fail to meet up to their exacting standards.
- Do not take their bluntness personally, it is not directed at you but the job itself.
- Whenever possible, try to point their attention to the broader situation so as to minimize their preoccupation with perfect execution of small tasks.

Dutiful (Dependent)

- They are likely to put off taking decisions, so present them with as clear a picture of the facts as possible.
- Be willing to step in for them in key moments; e.g., pitches and presentations.
- Provide support and positive feedback often.
- Emphasize the good aspects of the decisions they have made to help them stick to them.

Excitable (Borderline)

- Do not take their “changes of heart” personally.
- Where possible, get written instructions to back up your actions.
- Be careful not to antagonize their fragile ego.
- Be prepared for exaggerated reactions to any unpleasant news.
- Speak in short, clear and simple sentences, leaving no room for misinterpretation.

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Skeptical (Paranoid)

- Ensure you come across as devoted.
- Do not make promises you cannot keep, ask for clear descriptions of every task, be scrupulously honest in all of your activities.
- Be as transparent as possible in your work and communication.

Cautious (Avoidant)

- Encourage them to outline the task as clearly as possible.
- Actively seek constructive criticism from them.
- Be vigilant for less scrupulous colleagues seeking to take advantage of them.

Detached (Schizoid)

- Ask for instructions as they will not be forthcoming.
- Be aware of their tendency to be a stickler for detail.
- Do not waste time with flattery, it won't work.

Leisurely (Avoidant)

- Provide praise for tasks and activities done well, thus making them feel appreciated.
- If decisions need to be made on their part, present them with clear information and not too many options.
- Give arguments for why success is likely in a given project or task, in order to motivate action.

How to Deal With a Difficult Character Over Whom You Have Authority

Having a difficult character who reports to you may feel like a pain but it is also a tremendous opportunity for coaching this person. Such a character may well have enormous potential: "the bigger the talent, the more likely the person has some irritating tendency."[21]

As outlined in the introduction, dark traits should be viewed on a sliding scale, the key is not to eliminate personality weaknesses but to manage and optimize them.

It is therefore important that all coaching should be with a view to helping the individual develop within their character habits of self-directedness and cooperativeness to better manage their dark trait.

Finally, remember that these characters will be on their best behavior in front of a superior so be sure to source (and take seriously) feedback from subordinates in order to understand the traits they are exhibiting in the workplace.

[21] Rob Kaiser, "Dealing with the Dark Side," *Talent Quarterly*.

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As a general recommendation, keep in mind these three proven approaches for facilitating change in others: 1) leverage on the positive; 2) highlight the beneficial impact that changing might have on others (transcendent, prosocial motivation for change); and 3) transmit optimism and hope that change is possible, though not easy.

Bold (Narcissistic)

- When an employee is doing an acceptable job, a hand-on-the-shoulder approach may be effective.
- Devote more time to the feedback process with them. They will be resistant, but positive results are possible by framing discussions from the perspective of what they can achieve.
- Ensure they are rewarded for implementation rather than generation of ideas.

Colorful (Histrionic)

- Allow them to play to their strengths, ensuring they have a people-focused role.
- Take a proactive approach in describing and reinforcing work-relevant behavior.
- Encourage them to step away from the limelight and take supporting roles, as well as to genuinely praise others.
- Encourage introspection.
- Frame objectives and goals in terms of measurable and timely results.

Mischievous (Anti-Social)

- Give clear directions and monitor performance closely.
- Try to harness natural energy and enthusiasm by delegating stimulating, short-term tasks.
- Do not be lenient regarding deadlines or thoroughness of tasks.
- Emphasize and sell them the benefits that they themselves will obtain from collaborating well with others and being more transparent in their motives.
- Challenge them to test out any ideas they are not sure about by talking them out with others or looking for objective evidence.

Imaginative (Schizotypal)

- Ask them very specific questions.
- Encourage them to seek the creative or innovative parts of a task or their jobs.
- Encourage them to surround themselves and seek support from people who are attentive to detail, organized and focused on the process of execution.

Diligent (Obsessive-Compulsive)

- Challenge them to think about the big picture.
- Force them to adopt people-focused objectives.
- Do not over-criticize (they will be criticizing themselves enough).
- Make the case to them about how introducing a little more flexibility can be beneficial for others and for the work itself.

Dutiful (Dependent)

- Reinforce good behavior without over-criticizing the bad.
- Be cognizant of their overwhelming desire to do well.
- Encourage them to form their own opinions and seek solutions without help.
- Discourage them from excessive apologizing, blaming or complaining.

Excitable (Borderline)

- Try to provide them with a model of stability and reliability at work.
- Give constructive criticism in as positive a context as possible.
- Do not be lenient on deadlines, etc., and demand results from them.
- Keep focusing on your message, do not let them change the topic and avoid demonstrating emotional involvement.

Skeptical (Paranoid)

- Be careful not to engage in any behavior that they could use as a form of retribution.
- Ensure they view advancement as a true meritocracy.
- Ensure they have people-focused objectives.
- Aim for transparency in communication.

Cautious (Avoidant)

- Give them specific tasks to do and respect their desire to stay out of the spotlight.
- Recognize their aptitude for technical or mechanical tasks.
- Ensure they have the time to pursue outside interests/hobbies.

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Detached (Schizoid)

- Provide them with interpersonal distance and non-threatening support.
- Do not rely on typical motivational techniques, simply provide clear delegation and allow them to complete the task.
- In the long term, regular supervision sessions will be necessary to show them the need for some corporate conformity.

Leisurely (Avoidant)

- Provide them with an opportunity to excel at something, thereby demonstrating success does not come from unfair advantages but due to talent and hard work.
- Encourage them to shadow suitable role models who can show them the secrets to their success.
- Provide them with a completely objective mentor who will be able to disprove their conspiracy theories in a way they will believe.
- Encourage them to separate large tasks into small parts and assist them in having clarity before beginning a task.
- Praise effort rather than results.

Conclusion

In summary, dark side traits are present in many of us and you will likely encounter people in your career who exhibit one or more. Despite the frictions they may cause in working relationships, such traits may be a key part in what makes an individual successful. It is therefore important to help such people manage their dark side rather than write them off as difficult characters.

The key to dealing with difficult characters is to first identify the dark trait they possess. This observation can be performed personally, through feedback (of which upwards feedback is most relevant) or analysis of personality test results. Once you are cognizant of the individual's dark traits, you should first try to better understand how they view the world and consider and develop a repertoire of responses.

If you are not in a position to influence the individual, you should attempt to adjust your own behavior to prevent the individual from lapsing into behaviors linked to their dark traits. However, if you are the person in a position of responsibility, there are many ways you can tailor your approach to help those in lower positions manage and optimize their dark traits.

Finally, consider that "our greatest talents often spring from wounds and quirks, from rougher, less conformist sides of ourselves. Much resolve flows from restlessness, creativity from angst, and resilience from having faced challenges we'd rather not share. Managers who are empathetic (and thus great with people) sometimes get overwhelmed by emotions. Don't fight these darker sources of your talent. Learn to channel them." [22]

[22] Jennifer Petriglieri, and Gianpiero Petriglieri, "The Talent Curse," *Harvard Business Review,* Volume 98, Issue no. 3 (2017) pp. 88-94.

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